

the early hours of Monday morning, Lehman Brothers filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy protection, making it the biggest bankruptcy in U.S. history. So came to an end a 164-year-old firm born from a dry-goods store that had evolved into the fourth largest U.S. investment bank. It signaled the end of an era.<sup>18</sup>

Lehman's bankruptcy and Merrill's buyout proved to be only the beginning. On Tuesday, the Federal Reserve Bank of New York was authorized to lend up to \$85 billion to the American International Group (AIG), the biggest insurer in America, as the behemoth organization began to teeter.<sup>19</sup> It was mid- September and darker clouds loomed on the horizon for Wall Street and global financial markets.

## THE BIRTH OF BITCOIN

Six and a half weeks later, on October 31, 2008, Satoshi released the Bitcoin white paper, which serves as the genesis for every single blockchain implementation deployed today and forevermore. In the concluding paragraph of his foundational paper, Satoshi wrote: "We have proposed a system for electronic transactions without relying on trust."<sup>20</sup>

By the time he released the paper, he had already coded the entire system. In his own words, "I had to write all the code before I could convince myself that I could solve every problem, then I wrote the paper."<sup>21</sup> Based on historical estimates, Satoshi likely started formalizing the Bitcoin concept sometime in late 2006 and started coding it around